Lahiri had a degree in interior designing from Jadavpur University and, during Covid, decided to set up her own design firm—Mystt. "It was a big challenge. But I felt... it had to be now. The new sense of the uncertainty of life perhaps brought me to my dreams. You can't leave your dreams on the shelf. You have to take them out and live them," says Sunita. The last of the trio, Ranu Mandal, a home-maker, took the culinary route and started her own catering outlet—MohonBhog. She had always wanted to open a food joint or do catering but never had the courage to take the plunge. "Difficult times make you wise and philosophical. The pandemic helped me," she says.

Some, in fact, found a calling they didn't even know they had in them. While cooking for friends and family in the lockdown, 46-year-old Sunita Zacharia realised there was a need for "well-cooked and convenient food" in her home city of Bengaluru. Together with fellow homemaker and friend Sneha Mathew, 43, she launched Spice Boat, which sells homemade masalas, spice pastes and *podi*s (powders). "This company brings me so much joy. Simply to hear a customer say that my *podi* reminds them of their grandmother is so fulfilling! And Covid showed me the market potential for this venture," says Zacharia.

If planning is part of it, impulse, too, is not absent—the economic challenges of the pandemic bringing a twist to the usual thrift of Indians. A 2021 survey by Deloitte India found that 85 per cent of those surveyed planned to spend on leisure travel in the next month. And 74 per cent were planning to buy a vehicle in the next six months. This paradoxical reaction to crisis is not an unknown phenomenon—it's often witnessed in the aftermath of catastrophes. After the Second World War, the baby boomers created a market for items that were deemed 'luxury' earlier. Sales of washing machines, cars and telephones spiralled in the '60s-70s. In India, Mercedes Benz has reported its highest sales ever this year! Orders run in excess of Rs 3,500 crore, and demand is coming even from smaller cities like Guwahati, Surat, Ahmedabad and Chandigarh.

Bakshish Dean, 51, did not settle for one dream. He went on close to 20 holidays with his family, and also bought a costly car. A chef of some repute, who worked 22 years in hospitality and brought the American chain Johnny Rockets to India, Dean worked 15 hours a day on average before the pandemic. "I would run around like a crazy person, attending meetings in different cities. I felt like popcorn on a skillet." But the pandemic brought all work to a grinding halt. "Payments didn't come through, or were interminably delayed...a project in Mauritius was stalled. Both my wife and daughter freelance, so when money stopped, it was literally from all quarters," says Dean. Like all families, they hunkered down for the long, collective incarceration of the lockdown, distributing household chores among themselves.

But then, Dean lost a very close friend of his. "He was supposed to be discharged in a day from hospital. But within 24 hours, he was gone. His father, too, passed away within three days. Then, a junior colleague lost his 34-year-old brother, who had two small kids. Messages of death and disease filled our lives, and I realised we don't have as much time as we think we do." The family of four—mother, father, daughter and elderly grandmother—began to eat all meals together at the table. And being together then took another form...as wanderlust struck. "We took about 18-20 holidays, including four international holidays (Dubai, Maldives and Sri Lanka); people thought we

MANDAR DEODHAR



» **AMIT CHOPRA,** *56*

MD, India & South Asia, Thermo Fisher Scientific, ***Mumbai***

Dream fulfilled

Started bird-watching as a hobby

How Covid changed me

"Covid was challenging for everyone and I felt I needed a passion to pursue. It was important to retain a sense of balance"